in political argument, the concept of national interest is used to explain, evaluate, rationalize or criticize foreign policy.[19]

However, a powerful objective exposition of national interest was given by Morgenthau. Though highly criticized, yet not without value and relevance, he contended that statesmen think and act according to interest defined in terms of power. The content of national interest is determined by the political traditions and the total cultural context within which a nation operates. Inherent in the meaning of national interest is the minimum requirement of states to protect their physical, political and cultural identity against aggressions by other states. Therefore, the residual meaning inherent in national interest is 'survival'. 'Survival' involves preservation of physical identity, i.e., maintenance of territorial integrity, preservation of political identity, i.e., preservation of existing politico-economic regimes, preservation of cultural identity, i.e., conservation of ethnic, religious, linguistic and historical norms found in a state. From these general objectives, Morgenthau, argues that the statesmen derive their specific policies which may range from cooperative to conflictive policies like competitive armaments, balance of power, foreign-aid, alliances, subversion and economic and propaganda 'warfare'. [20]

On the whole, as Clinton[21] points out 'the national interest' refers to a general regulative principle of diplomacy, which represents the common good of the society, in its relations with other national units, as the end of diplomatic action. But the usage of the term 'the national interests' refers to myriad narrower goals which serve the broader end of 'the national interest' by maintaining or increasing the power of the state. National interests may range from vital or primary interests to secondary interests and again from permanent to variable interests. There can also be general interests and specific interests. Simultaneously, there can be in the international arena a play between identical interests, complementary interests and conflicting interests. The main purpose of the whole idea of national interest is in giving direction to long-term objectives of the foreign policy of a state and giving meaning to its actions in a short-term context.